



From Greek to Latin Europe and back: recovering and interpreting Theophrastus' *De odoribus* in the early modern age

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ABSTRACT

The article traces the reception history of Theophrastus' *De odoribus* in the early modern period. It first examines the recovery and circulation of the earliest manuscript witnesses of the work in fifteenth-century Italy and the publication in print of the Greek text (Venice, 1497). As a work devoted to the preparation and usages of unguents and powders, the *De odoribus* provided a useful repertoire of recipes for botanists and other practitioners of the life sciences. The work, however, was transmitted very poorly, so that early modern scholars had to engage in meticulous philological analyses in order to restore the text's readability. The second part of the article focuses on the Latin translations of and philological commentaries on the work produced between the mid-sixteenth and the early seventeenth century. These were made by Adrian Turnèbe (1556), Jacques Daléchamps (ca. 1575), and Daniel Furlanos (printed in 1605, but completed before), the last being a Greek scholar who, after years of activity spent in Padua, eventually returned to his native Crete to bring his work on Theophrastus to completion. The article shows that, while Turnèbe remained the standard authority for the interpretation of Theophrastus' *De odoribus*, both Daléchamps and Furlanos contributed to the further improvement of the text and paid special attention to the medical framework of the work.

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1. Introduction

In Europe the period between the early fifteenth and the early sixteenth century was a prime time for the recovery of Peripatetic scientific literature. It saw the reappearance of a wide array of texts that added significantly to the existing catalogue of works devoted to Aristotle's natural philosophy.¹ The rediscovery of this vast corpus of writings (pseudo-Aristotelian treatises, books composed within the Peripatos by Aristotle's

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¹General surveys have been provided by Anthony Grafton, 'The Availability of Ancient Works', in *The Cambridge History of Renaissance Philosophy*, ed. by Charles B. Schmitt, Quentin Skinner, Eckhard Kessler, Jill Kraye (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1988), pp. 763–91 (pp. 777–8); James Hankins and Ada Palmer, *The Recovery of Ancient Philosophy in the Renaissance: A Brief Guide* (Florence: Olschki, 2008), pp. 20–33. A complete list of all printed editions of Aristotle's works produced in the period 1450–1650, which builds on the previous surveys made by Ferdinand Cranz and Charles Schmitt, has been recently made available in volume 2 of Charles H. Lohr, *The Aristotelian Tradition (1200–1650): Translations, Themes and Editions*, ed. by Christoph Lüthy and Andrea Aldo Robiglio (Florence: Sismel-Edizioni del Galluzzo, 2023).

students, late ancient commentaries on the Philosopher's works) had a tremendous impact on how European scholars approached and interpreted Aristotle's thought in the early modern age.² Ultimately, this wealth of new material was responsible for a profound reshaping of the landscape of the until-then dominant Peripatetic philosophy at the threshold of the 'Scientific Revolution'. Among the many sources recovered and made available to the European Latinate audience, some explicitly challenged Aristotle's natural philosophy. This is especially true of the works of some late ancient Greek interpreters of his thought. The commentary on the *Physics* penned by the sixth-century Alexandrian philosopher John Philoponus (490-570 CE), for instance, is known to have contributed to the dismantling of crucial concepts of Aristotle's physical conception, such as motion, the nature of space and the existence of void space in nature.³ By contrast, other sources helped to support Aristotle's views on points he did not fully discuss in his known works. This is the case, for example, with the pseudo-Aristotelian *Mechanica*, a key text for Renaissance engineering.⁴ Still, other sources provided early modern scholars with insight into matters that Aristotle did not treat *at all* in his extant corpus. They complemented Aristotle's works by offering discussions that would typically follow from Aristotelian premises and share the same methodology and style adopted by Aristotle. Within this last group, the works of Theophrastus occupy a prominent position.

Theophrastus of Eresus (ca. 370-278 BCE) was Aristotle's student and second head of the Lyceum in Athens from 322 to 278 BCE.⁵ On succeeding Aristotle, he undertook the formidable task of continuing his master's wide-ranging activities.⁶ We know that he kept on lecturing on almost all the subjects taught by Aristotle, thus contributing to the consolidation of the various disciplines cultivated by the school's founder. As a thinker, however, Theophrastus showed himself to be especially interested in the physical sciences, a predilection that was to be followed by many of his colleagues and students. Therefore, while his teaching activities were largely continuous with Aristotle's orientation, Theophrastus also marked a transition in the history of the Peripatetic school. His successor in the school, Strato of Lampsacus (335-269 BCE),⁷ who brought this shift of attention to full development, was unsurprisingly nicknamed 'the natural philosopher' (ὁ φύσικος).⁸

Theophrastus' extensive catalogue of natural philosophy works is clear witness to his interests in and vast learning about the subject. He took up investigations in such

²Luca Bianchi, 'Continuity and Change in the Aristotelian Tradition', in *The Cambridge Companion to Renaissance Philosophy*, ed. by James Hankins (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2007), pp. 49–71.

³See Richard Sorabji, *John Philoponus and the Rejection of Aristotelian Science* (London: Duckworth, 1987); Richard Sorabji, *Matter, Space, & Motion: Theories in Antiquity and Their Sequel* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 1988). On space in particular, see Ioannis Papachristou, *John Philoponus on Physical Place* (Leuven: Leuven University Press, 2021).

⁴Hankins and Palmer, *The Recovery of Ancient Philosophy*, p. 24; Paul Lawrence Rose and Stillman Drake, 'The Pseudo-Aristotelian Questions on Mechanics in Renaissance Culture', *Studies in the Renaissance*, 18 (1971), 65–104; Walter Roy Laird, *The Renaissance of Mechanics: Ancient Science in the Age of Humanisms* (Cham: Springer, 2024), pp. 149–166.

⁵Bio-bibliographical accounts of Theophrastus may be found in Jean-Pierre Schneider, 'Théophraste d'Èrèse', in *Dictionnaire des Philosophes Antiques*, ed. by Richard Goulet, vol. 6 (Paris: CNRS Editions, 2016), pp. 1034–1122; Katerina Ierodiakonou, 'Theophrastus', in *The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*, ed. by Edward N. Zalta (Winter 2020 Edition).

⁶See Tiziano Dorandi, 'Qualche aspetto della vita di Teofrasto e il Liceo dopo Aristotele', in *Theophrastus: Reappraising the Sources*, ed. by Johannes M. van Ophuijsen and Marlein van Raalte (London-New York: Routledge, 1998), pp. 29–38.

⁷See Robert W. Sharples, 'Theophrastus as Philosopher and Aristotelian', in *Theophrastus: Reappraising the Sources*, pp. 272–6.

⁸This account is largely based on Hans Balthussen, *Theophrastus against the Presocratics and Plato: Peripatetic Dialectic in the De Sensibus* (Leiden-Boston: Brill, 2000), pp. 11–12.

numerous and diverse disciplines as botany, zoology, minerology, meteorology, and physiology.⁹ Among these writings, the opusculum entitled *On odors* (Περί ὀδμῶν or Περί ὀσμῶν, *De odoribus*, as it was later known in the Latin world) went on to enjoy remarkable success in the early modern European world. The *De odoribus* marks an important milestone in ancient discussions on the sense of smell. Theophrastus adopts Aristotle's conceptual framework as laid out in *De anima* (421a7-422a7) and *De sensu et sensato* (442b27-445b2) and applies it to the production of artificial odors.¹⁰ As he states at the outset, his *De odoribus* will be concerned with those odors that one makes *κατά τέχνην και ἐπίνοιαν* ('through art and invention').¹¹ After a summary of the main principles of Aristotle's conception of smell, the work discusses the basic techniques for the production of odorous unguents (ἀρώματα). The subsequent sections deal with the preservation of unguents through oils and the different types of oil to be used in each case. Theophrastus also devotes considerable attention to the specific ingredients (plants, leaves, berries) to be used for the preparation of unguents. Towards the midpoint of the work, the author makes a lengthy digression on the medical properties of some unguents. After further discussion on the composition of oily unguents, Theophrastus briefly deals with the production of powders (διαβάσματα), that is, the dry counterpart of unguents. The final sections of the work appear loosely related to what Theophrastus had argued up to that point, as they discuss topics such as stones, fossils, and metals.¹² Scholars tend to take these sections as disconnected fragments that do not belong to the treatise.¹³

We now know that the text known as *De odoribus* was in fact the eighth and last book of Theophrastus' *De causis plantarum*.¹⁴ *De causis*, as it has been handed down by tradition, comprises only six books. Internal references show, however, that the treatise had originally consisted of eight books, a fact that is also confirmed by Diogenes Laertius.¹⁵ As has been shown, books 6, 7 and 8 were designed to form a thematically coherent section. While book 6 discussed natural flavors and odors, book 7 (now lost) was devoted to artificial flavors.¹⁶ Finally, book 8 (i.e. *De odoribus*) focused on artificial odors, such as the scents of unguents and perfumes.¹⁷ At an early stage in the textual tradition, these last two books must have begun to circulate independently. As early as the third century CE,

⁹See Diogenes Laertius, *Lives of Eminent Philosophers*, ed. by Tiziano Dorandi (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2013), pp. 370–78.

¹⁰Hans Baltussen, 'Ancient Philosophers and the Sense of Smell', in *Smell and the Ancient Senses*, ed. by Mark Bradley (London-New York: Routledge, 2015), pp. 30–45 (pp. 40–5). For a learned discussion of Theophrastus' views on smells, see Robert W. Sharples, 'Theophrastus on tastes and smells', in *Theophrastus of Eresus. On his life and work*, ed. by William W. Fortenbaugh, Pamela M. Huby and Anthony A. Long (New Brunswick-Oxford: Transaction, 1985), pp. 183–204 (esp. pp. 193–7).

¹¹Theophrastus, *Concerning Odors*, ed. by Arthur Hort (London, Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2014), p. 332.

¹²See Georg Wöhrle, 'The structure and function of Theophrastus' treatise *De odoribus*', in *Theophrastean Studies: On natural science, physics and metaphysics, ethics, religion, and rhetoric*, ed. by William W. Fortenbaugh and Robert W. Sharples (New Brunswick-Oxford: Transaction, 1988), pp. 3–13.

¹³See the introduction to the critical edition of Theophrastus, *De odoribus*, ed. by Ulrich Eigler, Georg Wöhrle, and Bernhard Herzog (Stuttgart: Teubner, 1993), p. 15; Wöhrle, 'The structure and function of Theophrastus' treatise *De odoribus*', pp. 3–4.

¹⁴See Wöhrle, 'The structure and function of Theophrastus' treatise *De odoribus*', pp. 3–4, who bases his argument on G. R. Thompson's unpublished dissertation of 1941. See also Michael G. Sollenberger, 'Identification of titles of botanical works of Theophrastus', in *Theophrastean Studies*, pp. 14–24 (pp. 18–9).

¹⁵Diogenes Laertius, *Lives*, p. 373: 'Φυτικῶν αἰτιῶν α' β' γ' δ' ε' ζ' η'.

¹⁶This was probably the treatise *On wine and oil* (Περί οἴνου καὶ ἐλαίου) mentioned by Diogenes Laertius. See Wöhrle, 'The structure and function of Theophrastus' treatise *De odoribus*', p. 4.

¹⁷See Theophrastus, *De odoribus*, p. 11.

Diogenes Laertius referred to them as two separate works.¹⁸ If Diogenes Laertius is to be trusted, it may indicate that the content of the *De odoribus* was seen as a quarry of practical information and techniques to be applied to the fields of pharmacology and perfumery, a stand-alone treatment that did not necessarily presuppose acquaintance with the other sections of the *De causis*.

Indeed, the importance of Theophrastus' *De odoribus* lies in its combination of theory and practice. Theophrastus starts from Aristotle's theoretical premises and provides a concrete application of his tenets. By doing so, he contributes to a further consolidation of Aristotle's account and affirms its validity beyond the realm of pure speculation. The work has the merit of dealing with topics (unguents, powders, oils) that Aristotle had not covered in his works, including most notably the medical and cosmetic properties of some herbs and mixtures. It is precisely this aspect that attracted the attention of early modern readers.

Despite its importance as a systematic treatment of odors *more aristotelico*, however, the text of the *De odoribus* is lacunose and ends abruptly after 69 paragraphs, being much shorter in that form than all other books included in the *De causis plantarum*. Also, like other Theophrastean opuscula, the *De odoribus* includes several obscure passages. When the work was recovered in the fifteenth century, it forced scholars to engage in extensive philological analyses aimed at restoring the text's readability at several different levels. This article traces the reception history of this work in the early modern period. It first discusses the recovery of the text during the fifteenth century and the challenges faced by the earliest editors of the Greek text (Venice, 1497). Then, it focuses on the Latin translations of and philological commentaries on the work produced between the mid-sixteenth and the early seventeenth century. These were made by Adrian Turnèbe (1556), Jacques Daléchamps (ca. 1575), and Daniel Furlanos (printed in 1605, but completed before), the last being a Greek scholar who, after spending years of activity in Padua, eventually returned to his native Crete to bring his work on Theophrastus to completion. All these works show that philological quarrels over the interpretation of the text continued well into the century and by no means came to an end with the publication in print of the Greek text. On the contrary, they marked a phase of unprecedented engagement with the transmitted text. The adoption of different translation and exegetical strategies in these readings led to a further improvement of the Greek text and testify to the efforts made by early modern scholars to make sense of this complex, yet highly useful, work.

2. Theophrastus' *De odoribus*: from manuscript to print

Although he was a highly prolific author, with a catalogue of writings comprising more than 200 items as reported by Diogenes Laertius, Theophrastus was practically unknown in the European Middle Ages. In the early Middle Ages, only small fragments of his works were cited by Johannes Scotus Eriugena (ca. 800-ca. 877 CE) and by other writers from his school. Furthermore, several writings now attributed to Theophrastus were known in Latin translation after the thirteenth century, but they seem to have always circulated under the name of Aristotle, such as *De signis*, the *Metaphysica* and

¹⁸Diogenes Laertius, *Lives*, p. 372 ('Περὶ ὀσμῶν α') and p. 373 ('Φυτικῶν αἰτιῶν α' β' γ' δ' ε' ζ' η').